TRU 110: SELF & SOCIETY – SEMINAR IN THE MORAL SCIENCES

TRUMAN STATE UNIVERSITY — FALL 2020 — 3 CREDITS

Professor: David Gillette Office: MC 206A Phone: x4334
Office Hours: MWF 10:30-noon; T&H 11:30-12:30 & 4:00-5:30 PM; and by appt. E-Mail: gillette@truman.edu
Exceptions include Thursdays when Undergraduate Council meets: 8/20, 9/10, 10/8, 11/5, & 12/3
and Tuesdays when our Department meets: TBD. To offset these exceptions when possible,
I will offer an added Tuesday hour from 6-7 pm and Thursday from 5-6 pm.

Welcome to Self & Society. We have an exciting semester that includes the following learning outcomes:

- understanding the moral sciences and the liberal arts
- understanding the benefits of the liberal arts and sciences and the importance of lifelong learning
- understanding what a "discipline" is, and how various disciplines, including students own field of study, are positioned within the larger mosaic of knowledge
- applying the tools and theoretical frameworks of the moral sciences
- understanding the relationship between self & society through the exploration of the moral sciences, data, and statistics
- exploring "Big Questions" of intellectual, regional, national, and global importance, both in class and in Truman's Symposium
- understanding diverse ideas, perspectives, and opinions while considering their merits
- honing critical thinking and problem-solving skills
- developing essential digital literacy skills
- improving the ability to analyze and evaluate information in a well-reasoned way
- improving the ability to engage with others effectively through speech and writing
- experiencing and critically reflecting about the benefits of community engagement
- collaborating and sharing ideas with their peers
- understanding economic principles found in the moral sciences and how they affect our lives wherever we live
- understanding the role of incentives in the moral sciences including individual and firm behavior in a market-oriented society
- understanding the role of institutional structure in aligning self-interest with social interest
- understanding the role of marginal analysis and tradeoffs both for oneself and in society
- using data to answer questions, form a more accurate understanding of the world, and to beat the chimps
- using the moral sciences to explore when intervention is useful or harmful
- and using the moral sciences to explore ethics and public policy.

Prerequisites: Except for literacy and a genuine desire to learn, there are no pre-requisites for this course.

Required Materials: FACTFULNESS, by Hans Rosling; UNDERSTANDING STATISTICS by Antony Davies and other readings provided on Blackboard throughout the semester.

Recommended Readings: You should read daily some kind of news publication reporting local, regional, national, and international economic events. Note that we have three news publications available on campus already (*New York Times, St. Louis Post Dispatch,* and *USA Today*). ***Words & Numbers*** is also informative, enjoyable, and entertaining (https://fee.org/articles/topics/words%20and%20numbers). You can find it in podcast format as well (either at their website or on iTunes). You might also want to regularly access the *Wall Street Journal,* or the *Washington Post*. Regular news consumption will enrich your experience in this course and deepen your understanding of society.

This course fills the LAS requirements (see http://www.truman.edu/majors-programs/requirements-at-a-glance/) for the Self & Society Requirement and provides an introductory exposure to the major investigative methods used by social scientists. This course will serve as an introduction to multidisciplinary thinking and will encourage students to be better consumers of information.

The next paragraph is the non-Covid attendance policy that I have decided to leave available to you in the syllabus for your awareness and reflection. Under the Information Tab on Blackboard I have posted the entirety of Truman's Temporary Attendance Policy, Senate Bill 0121. It says that I cannot give you any credit towards your grade for attending class, which also means I cannot deduct any points from your grade for missing class. It does not, however, mean that just reading the text and doing the homework will provide the same understanding and

mastery of the material as you will get from also attending class. This course does not use publisher PowerPoint slides. I generate 100% of the slides used in this class and use them to provide as many relevant examples from current events as possible. You will learn the most by attending class and engaging in that experience. In fact, I believe in the importance of our time together in class so much that I chose to teach an additional five hours each week this semester in order to provide that experience while still accommodating social distancing. Still, please do adhere to university guidelines about attendance when you are ill. Working together we (you & I) will do the best we can to keep you current in case of illness.

Since this course revolves around classroom experiences designed for each class period, attendance is required. (See: http://catalog.truman.edu/content.php?catoid=12&navoid=560#Attendance Policy for further information.) Learning Curve will give you credit for completing the assigned reading material before attending class. You are responsible to attend class every day, and to get the notes if for some reason you absolutely find an absence necessary. You will miss something important, and after the first two unexcused absences, each unexcused absence will result in the loss of a quarter of a letter grade for the course.

Make mastery of the course material your objective and earning a good grade will follow naturally. Because effectively learning about and employing the economic way of thinking requires students to engage and practice this material on a frequent and consistent basis, regular reading and discussion will provide that opportunity. Weekly Big Questions Homework assignments actively address, either through reflection and analysis, or through preparation and forethought, the current topic of class discussion. An average student should expect to spend at least two hours outside of class for each hour in class to become competent with this material.

The final component of your grade comes from various forms of class participation that include attendance (measured in part by *thoughtful* MITs), competent responses, discussion group participation, and my evaluation of your contribution to class discussions and activities. MITs are one or two sentence statements about the *most important thing* you learned in class that day, or they might also contain a lingering question that we did not get time to answer that I will address later in that day's online posting of the classes MITs.

In summary, your grade in this course will be determined as follows:

Assignments (ex. 4-year plan)	30
Projects	40
Presentation	15
Class Participation	15

In this class, "learning" falls under your responsibility. I will provide a stimulating environment, but you must bring the desire and drive to learn with you. I cannot, nor do I want to, force learning on any of you. On occasion, I might give extra credit assignments that anyone in the class may choose to do. However, I will not allow one person to do something extra at which the whole class does not have a shot. Should you have ideas for an additional learning opportunity, such as a relevant campus speaker or another event please let me know.

Finally, I am required to include a number of informational statements in my syllabus, beginning with academic integrity, Title IX, and ADA accommodations. I will not tolerate academic dishonesty, or discrimination of any type, in any form. For further explanation, please refer to section 8.05 of the Student Conduct Code: http://www.truman.edu/wp-content/uploads/2014/02/CHAPTER-8-REVISED-August-1-2015.pdf. If you need ADA accommodations, please see me as soon as possible and we can make those arrangements. One of my Title IX responsibilities is to help create a safe learning environment on our campus. In that role, I have a mandatory reporting responsibility and am required to share information regarding sexual misconduct or information about a crime that may have occurred on Truman's campus with the University. Students may speak to someone confidentially by contacting University Counseling Services at 660-785-4014 (660-665-5621 for after-hours crisis counseling.) Since it inhibits other students' ability to learn and an instructor's ability to teach, disruptive behavior that persistently or flagrantly interferes with classroom activities may be subject to disciplinary action. A student responsible for disruptive behavior may be asked to leave class pending discussion and resolution of the problem and may be reported to the Office of Student Conduct. Emergency Procedures can be reviewed here: http://police.truman.edu/files/2015/12/Emergency-Procedures.pdf and here: http://police.truman.edu/emergency-procedures/academic-buildings/. Your FERPA rights can be explored here: http://www.truman.edu/registrar/ferpa/.

Please stay current. Do not fall behind. If you have trouble, come and see me immediately! If you would just like to know if you are on the right track, come and see me then, too. On the other hand, if you just want to discuss the meaning of the universe, my door will always be open to you. My objective is to guide your learning while making the tour interesting, relevant, and enjoyable. Good luck to each of you; we will have a great semester.

Sincerely,

David Gillette